An IPS officer of the 1975-batch Jammu and Kashmir cadre, Raju had rich experience in tackling insurgency problems, and hence had a fine understanding of militancy and a militant's mind. Also, as SP, CBI, he had solved many cases of murder and corruption in the mid-1980s in Kerala. But his speciality was dealing with counter-insurgency, hence chosen for the job in the SIT. As number two to Kaarthikeyan, he played a key role in cracking the LTTE angle and proving it in the trial until the case was decided.

As earlier mentioned, he formed a strong duo with fellow DIG Amod Kanth and made the first big breakthrough in the case by solving the assassination case of EPRLF leader K. Padmanabha, which eventually led the SIT to suspect Sivarasan behind Rajiv Gandhi's assassination too. While Kaarthikeyan would be busy running around between Madras, Hyderabad and Delhi, Raju would lead the investigation.

Raju passed away in Kochi in June 2012.

CAPTAIN A.K. RAVINDRAN (33): National Security Guard

National Security Guard commando unit head Captain A.K. Ravindran was asked to be on standby with a thirty-member team of the Black Cat commandos by the Cabinet Secretariat hours after Rajiv Gandhi's assassination. They waited at the Palam airport in Delhi for two days before returning to their base in Manesar, Haryana. Captain Ravi felt devastated at the death of Rajiv Gandhi and was determined to punish the killers. He had a rich experience in tackling militants and in close-combat war with terrorists in Jammu and Kashmir and Punjab.

He reached Madras with his team in the third week of June and formed the tracking team to nab Sivarasan and gang along with the SIT. He had to face many setbacks in the course of tracking the mastermind due to the indecision of the senior members of the SIT and bureaucratic tangles. While he was trained to take swift action on suspects, his co-members from the local police were comparatively slow and operated only by the rulebook. This led to no results at all, often raising his frustrations. In the final